Later the Portuguese navy defeated the Zamorin of Calicut and captured Goa and made it its headquarters for all its possessions in the East. Thus the foundation of the Portuguese Empire in the East was laid.



Vasco da Gama

In 1519 A.D. (C.E.), Ferdinand Magellan sailed westward and crossed the Straits, which later came to be known as Magellan Straits. As the sea was calm he called it the Pacific Ocean. On reaching an island he named it as Philippines after the Spanish Prince Philip. He was killed in a war with the locals. However, the ship in which he had travelled returned to Spain. Thus the first circumnavigation of the world had taken place.

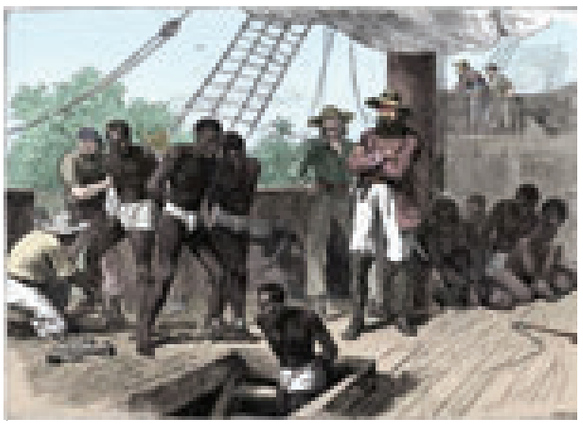
8.6 Impact of Geographical Discoveries

The geographical discoveries transformed the European understanding of the world. It led to the redrawing of the world map. As a result of the discovery of new lands and new sea routes, the economic centre of Europe shifted from the Italian city states to Spain and Portugal. Both Spain and Portugal established colonies that led to their economic prosperity.

One of the most important outcomes of the conquest of Americas by the European colonial powers was the movement of plants, animals, technology, culture and strange diseases between the Americas and Europe or between the **New World** and the **Old World**. This is known as **Columbian Exchange**.

Plants such as maize, potatoes, sweet potatoes, tomatoes, pineapple, beans and cocoa, and animals such as turkey and guinea pigs, were transported from America and introduced in Europe. And from Europe went sugarcane, wheat, rice, horses, cattle, sheep and goats to America. Europe also exported deadly diseases such as small pox, measles, chicken pox, malaria, typhus, etc. Apart from guns and horses, the most dangerous weapons the natives had to encounter were these deadly diseases against which they were defenceless. It led to the near annihilation of the natives in most parts of the Americas.

The introduction of sugarcane led to the establishment of sugarcane plantations in the Caribbean islands and South America. These plantations initially employed natives. The mass extinction of the native population led to the import of slaves from Africa. Gambia, Senegal, Goree, El Mina and Congo became important centres of slave trade in Africa. The Trans-Atlantic Trade was a triangular trade. The European countries purchased slaves from Africa who were transported to America. In return they got sugar and other raw materials from America. The European countries profited immensely from this trade.



Ship carrying slaves

Geographical discoveries led to Commercial Revolution. The chief features of commercial revolution were the emergence of banking, joint-stock companies and growth of trade.

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